

Environmental impact of ChatGPT

Posted by u/luv_u_deerly • 0 points • 32 comments

How do you guys feel about the environmental impact ChatGPT has? Do you use it less at all because of this? Or do you not care? I only just used it recently because I was curious and quickly found it very addicting. But then I heard about how much energy it actually takes and it's negative impacts and now I feel like it's very selfish to use it for stupid things like planning my 4 year old's birthday party. Or creating a shopping list for me. Perhaps I should save it for things that may be more important and debate whether I need it at all. Any thoughts?

Comments

u/Hilux_Avet_Hobie • 1 points • 2025-10-27 16:31 UTC

Don't really care. As long as cruise and cargo ships exist, along with private jets, there is nothing to worry about for us as individuals.

u/ChaosEmbers • 2 points • 2025-08-07 18:19 UTC

AI isn't the problem. Its us and the kind of civilization we've built.

Personally, I am concerned about this. You're going to get down-voted and so will I because not only do people not care about this but they'll deny and deflect the reality of the long term harm AI, and modern carbon-heavy lifestyles in general, are doing to the planet. I know because I spent a long time trying to get people to be aware of and work to change the trajectory we were on regarding climate change, pollution and unsustainable growth. People just didn't care, or if they did, they were then quickly looking for a way out of caring because, lets be honest, the technologically advanced world we've built is so gratifying and helpful in so many ways that just thinking about having to sacrifice some of it, or slow things down, works against our individual and collective drive for comfort, fitting in and more of everything.

For small things, easy things, I think it would be ideal to use locally hosted, low parameter models running on highly energy efficient hardware. That's what I do. Unfortunately, people are going to want to have the best model they can use even for small stuff like birthday party. Its also harder to set up a locally hosted model that just use a cloud model severed straight away via a web interface. The most energy efficient hardware (Apple M chips) are also very expensive up front.

u/VFacure_ • 1 points • 2025-08-07 17:54 UTC

It's like 3W per prompt according to OpenAI sources. I'm good. I waste more energy with the poor insulation in my apartment.

u/Inside_Anxiety6143 • 1 points • 2025-08-07 17:54 UTC

AI is our best bet at climate change right now. There is an initial cost we must pay for development, but the future will be shaped by superhuman AIs which will make massive efficiency gains in every sector of society.

u/ChaosEmbers • 1 points • 2025-08-07 18:29 UTC

You can believe that god-machines will fix all the problems, but that is a religious belief.

Efficiency has never led to a diminished amount of resources being consumed. Its led to an increase in what could be consumed. Renewable energy didn't stop the growth of fossil fuel use, it added to the total amount of energy available to us to grow even more quickly.

u/dethorin • 1 points • 2025-08-07 17:52 UTC

Eating meat and dairy products has more impact. I feel that changing slightly my diet would be better than making less questions to chatgpt.

u/luv_u_deerly • 1 points • 2025-08-07 20:39 UTC

I actually don't eat meat.

u/Sherpa_qwerty • 0 points • 2025-08-07 17:59 UTC

I legit love that you've made this calculation and also haven't done either reduce your ai usage or stopped eating meat. Bravo.

u/dethorin • 1 points • 2025-08-07 19:03 UTC

Oh, a strawman fallacy. Booring.

u/Sherpa_qwerty • 0 points • 2025-08-08 00:46 UTC

What is a strawman fallacy?

u/BachelorFan69420 • 2 points • 2025-08-07 18:18 UTC

Have you?

u/Sherpa_qwerty • 1 points • 2025-08-07 19:34 UTC

God no. I am saying I love the poster did it legit - not being a smartarse

u/SisterMarie21 • 2 points • 2025-08-07 17:50 UTC

You use the internet still, right? Or your phone or computer? Yes, AI uses a lot of energy, but that in itself isn't a problem. People who use that as a criticism aren't usually fair. You watch television for fun. Do you feel bad about the energy being used to do so? When people talk about the impact of AI, they do so to try to villainize every element of it.

u/luv_u_deerly • 1 points • 2025-08-07 20:39 UTC

But isn't the energy we use on AI way more than is used to browsing the internet and watching movies?

u/SisterMarie21 • 1 points • 2025-08-08 03:01 UTC

Yes, but it's all a fraction of energy use overall. We are always going to use electricity. The power needed to run our society is also going to keep increasing. The answer to the problems is not to shut off your power but to make more of it and have it be cleaner. I also dont really see this argument used anywhere else. When was the last time someone got angry with you for putting up Christmas lights?

u/Subnetwork • 1 points • 2025-08-07 17:50 UTC

I also remember how cloud computing and crypto were the next ecological doomsday things, people have such short memories unless it's the current "thing".

u/ChaosEmbers • 1 points • 2025-08-07 18:26 UTC

Those were and are bad news for the environment. Anything that uses electricity generated by fossil fuels, or an unsustainable source of energy and resources, adds to the predicament we now find ourselves trapped in.